

# Global Perspectives on Public Relations Theory: A Comparative Analysis of Non-Western Schools of Thought

## 1. Introduction: The Epistemological Imperative for Contextual PR Theory

The scholarly discourse on Public Relations (PR) has long been dominated by foundational theories originating in the United States and, to a lesser extent, Europe. This intellectual dominance, often referred to as the Anglo-American tradition, is characterized by the enduring influence of the Excellence Theory (ET).<sup>1</sup> ET, which emerged from multidisciplinary research drawing from management, psychology, and organizational communication<sup>3</sup>, presents a normative model suggesting that organizational effectiveness and ethical practice are best achieved through symmetrical, two-way communication.<sup>4</sup>

However, the universalist paradigm underlying ET has faced extensive critique for its inherent limitations in global application.<sup>1</sup> Critics argue that the theory is often rigid, overly organization-centric, and imposes a monocultural management model that fails to account for profound cultural, political, and historical variations globally.<sup>6</sup> This critique highlights the inadequacy of applying a single set of principles globally, arguing that "culture is far too complex" for such universal theorizing.<sup>2</sup> The Excellence model's foundational assumption—that excellent PR always leads to organizational effectiveness, is debated, particularly when addressing complex societal contexts.<sup>1</sup>

This intellectual tension has spurred the development of alternative theoretical positions. For instance, the European School of PR (ESPR) explicitly developed to challenge established U.S. perspectives.<sup>8</sup> ESPR scholars prioritize macro-level (societal) and meso-level (organizational) dynamics, emphasizing *reflectiveness*, the continuous process by which organizations consider and adjust their strategies based on societal standards, values, and norms.<sup>10</sup> This shift from focusing narrowly on organizational outputs to considering societal impact provides an essential conceptual pathway for exploring theories rooted in non-Western contexts.

The rise of contextual scholarship is therefore an imperative, calling for greater pluralism and inclusivity in PR research. This requires actively distancing global theory from traditional Western precepts of what constitutes democratic or ethical practice.<sup>12</sup> This analysis systematically addresses this theoretical void by examining the distinct contextual PR models across four critical non-Western geographical entities: Asia Pacific, the Middle East, South America, and Africa.

## 2. Theoretical Underpinnings of Asian Public Relations: Relationalism and Indigenous Contexts

Public relations scholarship in the expansive Asia Pacific (AP) region demonstrates a perpetual tension between the adaptation of Western management models and the need for indigenous theoretical frameworks. The challenge to generic principles is evident in the recognized conceptual gap, prompting a call for the thorough "excavation" of communication theories specific to Asian contexts.<sup>14</sup> This dynamic implies that existing Western structures, even when applied functionally, often remain culturally incomplete when attempting to fully describe local communication phenomena.

### 2.1 Relationalism and Cultural Foundations

The indigenous theoretical models of the Asia Pacific are overwhelmingly defined by a high degree of relationalism. Communication strategy is fundamentally interwoven with cultural concepts such as *Guanxi* (China), emphasizing hierarchical management, long-term relationship cultivation, and the preservation of social harmony. The complexity of the region, which encompasses vastly different governmental structures, levels of economic development, and cultural traditions, precludes the

formation of a singular, unified "Asian School." Instead, scholarly focus centres on contextualizing the generic models by prioritizing local norms of collectivism, hierarchy, and high-context communication.

The observed theoretical posture in AP scholarship involves a complex strategy of theoretical adaptation rather than outright rejection of foundational Western concepts. Whereas the European School *explicitly* developed alternative, reflective theories to challenge the managerial focus of the US model <sup>10</sup>, AP scholarship often demonstrates a tendency to functionally *apply* generic principles <sup>14</sup> while simultaneously recognizing and accommodating their inherent cultural deficiencies. This theoretical consequence leads to a framework described as Adaptive-Symmetrical. Organizations seek symmetrical outcomes of mutual benefit, yet this pursuit is conditional upon acceptance of culturally defined asymmetrical (hierarchical) relational structures. Therefore, achieving "mutual understanding" in many AP contexts is highly contingent on factors such as social status, reciprocal obligations, and the maintenance of organizational hierarchy.

## 2.2 Indigenous and Sub-Regional Nuances

Sub-regions within the Asia Pacific exhibit further theoretical differentiation. For example, in contexts involving Indigenous Australian populations, PR research demands a strong focus on **Indigenous Public Relations Theory**.<sup>15</sup> This model requires detailed relationship management, extensive community consultation, and the mandatory integration of Indigenous cultural elements into communication practices.<sup>15</sup> In such settings, PR must be two-way and strictly adhere to the protocols of the indigenous community, necessitating highly localized ethical guidelines.<sup>15</sup>

Furthermore, the rise of digital platforms has given social media a specific, non-Western theoretical function in relational-based cultures. While social media globally is credited with moving PR toward dialogic engagement <sup>16</sup>, in AP, these platforms are crucial for maintaining **social presence** and relational currency, rather than serving solely as rapid information dissemination channels.<sup>18</sup> This transforms the theoretical objective of digital PR from persuasive output to the visible, ongoing maintenance of established, long-term organizational relationships.<sup>18</sup> Relationship quality is measured through specific dimensions, including reciprocity, trust, mutual legitimacy, and commitment, which are essential for achieving shared solutions and mutual benefit.<sup>19</sup>

## 3. The Middle East Perspective: Geopolitical Strategy and Rhetorical Legitimacy

The Middle East (ME) presents a theoretical domain where public relations are almost inseparable from high-level institutional advocacy, strategic competition, and the intense pursuit of legitimacy. This context fundamentally differentiates the ME approach from the culturally driven relationalism of the Asia Pacific.

### 3.1 PR in the Geopolitical and Institutional Context

The geopolitical landscape of the Middle East is characterized by persistent strategic competition and conflicting security interests.<sup>21</sup> Consequently, PR is intrinsically linked to state advocacy, nation branding, and managing international perception in a high-stakes, volatile arena.<sup>21</sup> Organizational communication in many ME states is heavily influenced by centralized political structures, promoting a paradigm that leans heavily toward a Public Information and Advocacy Model. The primary objective is to secure national or institutional legitimacy and long-term stability, often serving political objectives.<sup>21</sup>

This environment produces a PR model that transcends mere market communication. It functions as Strategic Advocacy, where the managerial role of PR is directly leveraged to maintain socio-political stability and institutional control, distinguishing it from models focused solely on market share or consumer satisfaction. This is a pragmatic approach <sup>22</sup> centered on managing political risk and ensuring

organizational survival in complex strategic environments, unlike the reflective European model <sup>10</sup> or the highly idealized American symmetrical model.

### 3.2 Rhetorical Theory and Legitimacy in the Middle East

The theoretical approach of **rhetoric** is critical to understanding ME communication, especially concerning organizational values and public perception. Rhetoric highlights the function of public discourse through which ideas are contested, issues are examined, and consensus is sought to guide societal decisions.<sup>23</sup> This framework helps organizations gain legitimacy by placing their ideas under public scrutiny.<sup>24</sup> Research insights from regions like Türkiye confirm the necessity of measuring the perception and societal contribution of PR.<sup>24</sup> In a region where values and institutional stability are frequently contested, rhetoric is utilized to shape favourable public narratives and reinforce values alignment.

### 3.3 Differentiating ME from Asia Pacific

The fundamental theoretical distinction between the ME and AP lies in the core driver of the organization-public relationship. In AP, relationships are driven by *cultural and social exchange* for mutual benefit and harmony, prioritizing relational maintenance. In the ME, relationships, particularly with political stakeholders, media, and international publics, are often driven by **institutional necessity and political legitimacy** in a strategic environment.<sup>21</sup>

Strategic management theory discusses the choice between *bridging* (seeking alignment with stakeholders) and *buffering* (insulating the organization from external influence).<sup>26</sup> Given the institutional dominance and security concerns in the ME <sup>21</sup>, organizations frequently utilize a **buffering strategy** externally to manage complexity and risk. This differs markedly from the AP focus on external bridging for long-term relational security. Thus, while AP seeks consensus through relational maintenance, ME communication focuses on achieving concurrence through intense *public discourse and advocacy* aimed at securing political acceptance.<sup>24</sup>

## 4. South America and Africa: The Contextual Theories of the Global South

PR theories emerging from South America and Africa are often studied under the conceptual umbrella of the "Global South," sharing a core imperative to critique and move away from Western theoretical dominance.<sup>12</sup> This involves adopting a Critical/Reformist Stance <sup>28</sup> that focuses scholarly attention on issues of social power, ideology, and the deliberate transformation of society through *praxis* (the integration of theory and action).<sup>28</sup>

### 4.1. The African Perspective: Developmental and Deliberative Models

Public Relations theory in Africa is anchored in the region's historical and continuing mandate for socioeconomic development and stability. PR is viewed inherently as a tool for nation-building, development communication, and fostering systemic social change.

A primary theoretical alignment is found with Jürgen Habermas's theory of Communicative Action.<sup>31</sup> This model emphasizes reaching consensus through sincere dialogue, mutual understanding, and rational, argumentative communication.<sup>32</sup> Applied research demonstrates this framework's relevance in analysing democratic participation and governance (e.g., school governance in South Africa) <sup>31</sup>, offering a critical standard for evaluating constraints in the public sphere.<sup>34</sup> This application of the symmetrical ideal is pursued through a critical, social justice lens, defining dialogue as a means to achieve societal equity and political transformation, placing the ethical component at the core of theoretical value.

The practical context of the region, which requires organizations to deal with severe, immediate challenges (e.g., crisis communication during the COVID-19 pandemic <sup>16</sup> or complex environmental issues <sup>35</sup>), reinforces a reliance on a Pragmatic-Action Cycle Model.<sup>36</sup> Pragmatism is well-suited for

social sciences and bridging the theory-practice gap.<sup>38</sup> African PR theory emphasizes deep community engagement and the continuous adaptation of theory through knowledge put into action in everyday practice.<sup>37</sup> This results in a Developmental/Deliberative paradigm where ethical, community-focused communication is the normative standard.<sup>22</sup>

## 4.2. The South American Perspective: Political Agency and Global IR

The theoretical orientation of South American PR frequently intersects with Political Marketing and the concept of agency within the Global International Relations (IR) framework.<sup>40</sup> The focus is less on organizational development (the African priority) and more on the political entity's strategic role in the international order and the articulation of national interests.

Scholarship identifies "Southern middle powers" (such as Brazil) as adopting a distinct reformist stance that challenges the Western-centric dichotomy in global politics.<sup>13</sup> Public relations, therefore, assumes a critical role in strategic international reputation management, political advocacy, and redefining national identity. Theoretical models in South America prioritize enabling public voice and democratic participation at the macro-level.<sup>31</sup> This focus aligns closely with critical discourse studies<sup>30</sup>, viewing PR to address internal social stratification and external international pressures, positioning communication as a force for political transformation.

## 4.3. The Theoretical Importance of ESG and Ethical Context

The emergence of Environmental, Social, and Governance (ESG) criteria as a global PR theme<sup>41</sup> takes on a profound theoretical weight in the Global South. In regions grappling with severe environmental and social inequalities, ESG is not merely a marketing strategy; it is intrinsically linked to societal survival and legitimacy.<sup>43</sup>

The theoretical application of ESG in the Global South is inherently **Critical and Ethical**, focused on addressing historical oppression, institutional failures, and ensuring organizational accountability.<sup>33</sup> Transparent and aligned ESG reporting, coupled with clear communication, signals accountability and long-term vision, moving beyond potential organization-centric framings seen in some Western contexts.<sup>43</sup>

# 5. Comprehensive Comparative Analysis and Synthesis

The necessity of contextual PR theory stems from the stark divergence in core drivers and theoretical mandates across non-Western regions, providing evidence that a truly effective global strategy must be based on a localized understanding of power, culture, and social purpose.

## 5.1. A Comparative Framework of Non-Western PR Schools

The following structured comparison illustrates the fundamental intellectual and cultural drivers distinguishing the non-Western PR schools of thought:

### Comparative Analysis of Non-Western PR Theories

| Theoretical Dimension      | Asia Pacific (AP)                        | Middle East (ME)                                  | South America (SA)                                  | Africa                                             |
|----------------------------|------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Primary Goal/Focus</b>  | Cultivating Long-term Relational Harmony | Institutional Legitimacy & Geopolitical Advocacy  | Political/Social Agency & Institutional Reform      | Socioeconomic Development & Community Building     |
| <b>Dominant Philosophy</b> | Collectivism, High-Context, Hierarchy    | State/Institutional Authority, Rhetorical Contest | Critical Theory, Global IR, Social Change           | Developmental/Deliberative Pragmatism              |
| <b>Model Adaptation</b>    | Adaptive-Symmetrical                     | Managerial Advocacy (Buffering) <sup>21</sup>     | Critical Rhetoric/Activism (Bridging) <sup>13</sup> | Communicative Action (Praxis-driven) <sup>31</sup> |

|                             |                                              |                                              |                                                      |                                                     |
|-----------------------------|----------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------|
|                             | (Relational maintenance)                     |                                              |                                                      |                                                     |
| <b>Relationship Measure</b> | Trust, Commitment, Reciprocity <sup>19</sup> | Influence, Compliance, Strategic Positioning | Public Voice, Democratic Participation <sup>13</sup> | Mutual Understanding, Problem-Solving <sup>20</sup> |

## 5.2. Shared Characteristics: The Emergence of the Global South Perspective

Despite the geographical differences, the non-Western schools share fundamental characteristics that define a unified critique of the traditional mainstream:

1. **The Critical Stance and Societal Coupling:** All perspectives share scepticism toward purely managerial, self-interested PR.<sup>28</sup> They consistently emphasize the organization's **macro-level societal role**, mandating that PR reflect and adjust organizational behaviour based on societal standards and values.<sup>10</sup>
2. **Rhetoric as a Foundational Concept:** Rhetorical theory serves as a pervasive analytical concept, utilized in the ME for advocacy<sup>24</sup>, in SA for political agency<sup>13</sup>, and globally for shaping societal values and achieving concurrence.<sup>24</sup>

The contribution of non-Western theory building successfully addresses the persistent academic debate between managerial approaches and critical thought.<sup>46</sup> By grounding critical concepts, such as Habermas's communicative action<sup>31</sup>, in pragmatic applications related to development and crisis response<sup>16</sup>, these schools demonstrate how critical analysis informs ethical practice and organizational effectiveness simultaneously.

## 6. Conclusion: Recommendations for Advancing Contextual PR Theory

The comparative analysis confirms that non-Western regions contribute distinct and essential theoretical models that refine and complicate the understanding of global public relations. The theoretical contributions are not merely descriptive variations but represent fundamental shifts in the philosophical objectives of PR practice.

### 6.1. Distinct Theoretical Contributions by Region

- **Asia Pacific:** Contributes formalized **relational models** that define organizational value through non-Western relationship dimensions, such as reciprocity and commitment, providing a robust counterpoint to purely transactional relationship models.<sup>19</sup>
- **Middle East:** Advances sophisticated models that intrinsically link PR strategy to **geopolitical objectives and institutional legitimacy management**, developing the concept of **Strategic Advocacy** within contexts of high strategic competition.<sup>24</sup>
- **South America:** Offers theoretical frameworks for PR as a function of **Political Agency**, providing the necessary analytical tools for understanding "Southern middle power" communication and reformist stances in international contexts.<sup>13</sup>
- **Africa:** Validates the **Developmental/Deliberative** paradigm, demonstrating the practical application of Habermas's communicative action<sup>31</sup> as a normative standard for ethics-driven, community-focused communication essential for social change.<sup>22</sup>

### 6.2. Recommendations for Global Practice

For global communication strategists, the analysis necessitates moving beyond the generic framework by adopting a **Strategy-as-Practice (S-A-P)** approach.<sup>48</sup> S-A-P views strategy as an ongoing, adaptive activity informed by the specific social practices and cultural "modes of being" present in a locale.<sup>45</sup>

It is recommended that multinational organizations invest substantially in localized expertise and training for cross-functional teams. This ensures the integration of local cultural nuances, political dynamics, and indigenous communication protocols directly into communication strategies, achieving higher stakeholder trust, improved message clarity, and enhanced resilience in reputation management globally.<sup>15</sup> Effective global PR must be defined by contextual humility and the deliberate synthesis of these regional theoretical frameworks.

| School of Thought                       | Key Theories / Concepts                                                                                       | Core Scholars Cited                                                 |
|-----------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Managerial / Foundational School</b> | Four Models of Public Relations (Press Agency, Public Information, Two-Way Asymmetrical, Two-Way Symmetrical) | James E. Grunig, Todd Hunt                                          |
|                                         | Excellence Theory (Symmetry/Excellence Theory)                                                                | James E. Grunig, Larissa A. Grunig, David M. Dozier, Dennis Verčič  |
|                                         | Relationship Management Theory (RMT)                                                                          | Mary Ann Ferguson, Linda Hon, James E. Grunig, Ledingham, Bruning   |
| <b>Critical / Cultural School</b>       | Critical Theory (Critique of Power, Ideology, Praxis)                                                         | Antonio Gramsci (Hegemony) L'Etang                                  |
|                                         | Theory of Communicative Action (Public Sphere/Deliberation)                                                   | Jürgen Habermas                                                     |
|                                         | Critical Discourse Studies (CDS)                                                                              |                                                                     |
| <b>Rhetorical School</b>                | Rhetorical Theory (Advocacy, Concurrence, Symbolic Action)                                                    | Robert L. Heath, G.R. Miller (Persuasion)                           |
|                                         | Image Restoration Theory (Application in crisis)                                                              |                                                                     |
|                                         |                                                                                                               |                                                                     |
| <b>European School of PR (ESPR)</b>     | Reflectiveness Model (Coupling organization/society)                                                          | Betteke van Ruler, Dennis Verčič, Chiara Valentini, Vilma Luoma-aho |
| <b>Pragmatic Practice-Based School</b>  | Philosophical Pragmatism / Pragmatic Public                                                                   | John Dewey                                                          |
|                                         | Strategy-as-Practice (S-A-P) (Modes of Strategizing)                                                          | Mintzberg, Waters (related strategy types)                          |
|                                         | Situational Crisis Communication Theory (SCCT)                                                                | W. Timothy Coombs                                                   |
| <b>Global Contextual Models</b>         | Indigenous Australian PR Theory                                                                               | Clark, Peterson                                                     |
|                                         | Asian Relationalism / Social Presence                                                                         | Wimal Dissanayake, Nan Li                                           |
|                                         | African Developmental/Deliberative Model (Communicative Action application)                                   | Jürgen Habermas (Applied)                                           |
|                                         | South American Political Agency / Reformist Stance                                                            |                                                                     |
| <b>Emerging Theories</b>                | Normative Social Media Theory / Dialogic Engagement                                                           | Michael L. Kent, Chaoyuan Li, Katie Kelleher                        |
|                                         | ESG Storytelling / Sustainability                                                                             | Kenneth Hammond-Aryee                                               |